STORE MANAGER ESSENTIALS

Store Manager Essentials — Day 2: Run the Store Day to Day

Study guide · Self-study

Day 2: Run the Store Day to Day

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 2 of a five-day course. Day 1 set your stance as a manager: you own the result, you set a few priorities, and you protect time to manage. Today you turn that stance into the daily operation of a real store.

Work through each section in order. Write your answers down before you read the model answers at the end. The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

Every practice task gives you two options. Pick the one that fits you now:

If you manage a store now: use your own store, your own team, your own numbers.

If you are not a store manager yet: use your current shift, section or till area, use the fictional store in this guide, or role-play with a friend. Each option also shows you how the same skill answers a common store manager interview question.

When a task needs numbers, the guide gives a fictional practice example. Use those numbers as a model for your own estimates, and start recording your own numbers where you can.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the steps of the customer journey from walk-in to repeat visit, and why each step needs one named owner.

Attitude: You will treat the daily operation as something you design, not something that happens to you. You will stop patching the day and start shaping it.

Skill: You will be able to match staff hours to footfall peaks, write standards that hold on a bad day, and find the store's bottleneck before adding staff.

Upskill: You will write a short disruption plan for your store and use it to answer an interview question on how you run a busy day.

The Customer Journey From Walk-In to Repeat Visit

A store is a sequence of moments, and each moment has a customer in it. Most stores never write the sequence down. The result is that some steps have three people half-looking after them, and other steps have nobody.

Map the journey in your store and name one owner for each step. One owner, not a team. A team cannot be asked why a step failed. A person can.

The steps are usually these:

The walk-in. The customer arrives, sees the store and decides in seconds whether to stay.

The first contact. Someone greets, or the customer is left to wander. Either can work, but it has to be a decision, not an accident.

The browse. The customer looks around. The question is whether the layout and the labels help them find what they came for.

The help moment. The customer asks a question, or needs one and does not ask. This is often the step that decides the visit.

The add-on. The last useful suggestion before payment. Handled well it feels like help. Handled badly it feels like pressure.

The till. The customer pays. Speed and accuracy here shape the memory of the whole visit.

Delivery or collection. Online orders collected in store, or larger items arranged for delivery. This step is where many stores quietly lose repeat visits.

The return. Something goes wrong and the customer comes back. A fair, fast return is one of the cheapest ways to earn a repeat visit.

The repeat visit. The customer comes back, or does not. This step is the result of every earlier one.

Now the psychology. Why does one owner per step matter so much? When responsibility is shared, each person assumes someone else is handling it. The customer feels that gap immediately, even if they could never name it. A named owner also makes it possible to ask a fair question later: not "why is the till slow?" but "what happened at the till on Saturday?". That is a question about a step, not a person. People answer it honestly.

Second, people remember how a journey ends and how it peaked, more than they remember the average. A long wait at the till can outweigh a good conversation on the floor. The steps most stores leave unowned, the till and the returns desk, are exactly the ones customers remember last.

Practice example: A fictional store maps its journey and finds that the collection desk has no owner on weekday mornings. Two staff members assume the other is covering it. Orders wait on a shelf and customers wait at the counter. The manager names one owner per shift and asks them to check the shelf at the start of each hour. Over the next month, the number of collection complaints on weekday mornings falls from nine to two. Those figures are the store's own fictional example, not a benchmark.

Reflect: Draw your own journey in nine boxes. Name the owner under each box. Where do you write "everyone"? That is your first gap.

If you manage a store now: map the journey in your store this week. Walk it yourself from the door to the till and back.

If you are not a store manager yet: map the journey in the fictional store above, or in your own section from the customer's side only. Interview question this answers: "Walk me through how you would run a good Saturday in a busy store."

Matching Staff Hours to Footfall Peaks

Most stores already know their busy hours. The gap is that the schedule was written before anyone looked at them.

Start with the evidence you can see. Count customers at the door for a few days, in blocks of an hour. Write it down. You are not building a statistics project; you are checking whether the pattern you believe in is the pattern the store lives.

Then place people where the peak is. A footfall peak is not only a queue problem. It is a moment when the customer has a question and no one to ask. Put your strongest people on the floor and at the till during the peak, and put the stock work, the paperwork and the tidy-up outside it. Many stores do the opposite, because the stock work is easier to plan and the peak arrives by surprise.

The psychology here is about attention. A person doing a stock count does not see a customer who has been standing at the till for a minute. Attention is limited, and it goes where the task is. The schedule, not the person's goodwill, decides whether eyes are on the floor at the right time.

There is a second effect worth knowing. When the team is thin at the peak, the customers who wait are the ones who then face a rushed, tense staff member at the till. The staff member's stress spreads to the customer. Over time this becomes the store's reputation, and the team starts to expect bad Saturdays. A schedule that matches the real peaks is one of the cheapest morale fixes there is.

Here is a simple way to allocate hours. List each day's peak hours. List each person's hours. Put the strongest floor person in the middle of each peak. Put the stock and admin tasks in the quiet blocks. Leave one person free at the peak for the till, and one free for the floor. If the peak is longer than you have people for, say so and plan for it, rather than hoping it will be fine.

Practice example: A fictional store counts walk-ins on a Saturday and finds most arrive between two and five in the afternoon. Its current schedule has three staff on the floor in the morning, when footfall is light, and one at the till in the afternoon, when it is heavy. The manager moves one shift later by two hours. Nothing else changes and no one works more. The store's average queue at the till in the busy block drops from around six minutes to around three. These are fictional figures for practice, not a target.

There is another route worth knowing: build a peak plan for a single day and test it before you rewrite the whole week. One Saturday with the right coverage tells you more than a month of debate.

Reflect: When was your store busiest in the last seven days? Which hours were overstaffed? Write both answers down before you change anything.

If you manage a store now: check your busiest block against your schedule this week, and move one task, not one person's whole shift.

If you are not a store manager yet: in your section or till area, notice which hour is busiest and who is free then. Interview question this answers: "How would you make sure a busy Saturday does not fall apart?"

Watch out for a schedule that is balanced on paper but wrong in the store. The schedule decides the day, so check it against the door, not against the rota rules alone.

Standards That Hold on a Bad Day

A standard is not a hope. Say it as one observable behavior, so anyone could see whether it happened.

Compare these two. "The floor should look welcoming" is not a standard. "Every customer is greeted within a short time of entering" is a standard. You can watch for it. You can tell whether it happened. Someone who was not there can ask about it.

Now the harder part: a standard has to hold on a bad day. On a good day, with full staff and a calm store, almost anything holds. On a bad day, one person is off sick, a delivery is late and the till queue is long. That is the day that shows what the standard really is.

So write the standard in a way that survives. Name the minimum that must happen even on a busy day. "Greeting every customer" may be too much at a peak with one person on the floor. "Making eye contact and acknowledging every customer who reaches the till" may hold. Choose the version that survives, and be honest about the version that does not.

The psychology is simple and strong. People under pressure fall back on what is clear and few. A list of ten standards becomes a list of zero when the pressure arrives. One or two clear behaviors, repeated until they are automatic, survive. This is also why a standard you have explained once and never checked fades. The team reads your attention, not your signs on the wall. What you check, calmly and often, becomes the standard. What you never mention becomes optional.

There is a second effect. A standard that holds on a bad day builds trust with the team. When they see that the manager will not throw the standard away the moment the day gets rough, the standard stops feeling like a rule from above and starts feeling like how the store works.

How to write one:

Choose the step of the journey where quality matters most this month.

Write the behavior as something you can see.

Write the minimum version that holds on a busy day.

Name who checks it and when.

Tell the team why it matters to the customer.

Practice example: A fictional store's journey shows that the help moment is weak, and customers leave without asking. The manager writes one standard: whoever is on the floor asks every customer who stops at a shelf one open question about what they are looking for. On the store's busiest day it becomes: greet and ask, at least once, before the customer reaches the till. The check is simple: the manager walks the floor twice on Saturday and notes what they see. No names, no scores.

Reflect: Take one standard you use today. Can someone who was not there tell whether it happened? If not, rewrite it.

If you manage a store now: write one standard for your store and try it for a week.

If you are not a store manager yet: write one standard for your section or till area. Interview question this answers: "What does good service look like in your store?"

Finding the Bottleneck Before Adding Staff

When a store is slow, the first instinct is to ask for more people. That instinct is often wrong. A queue at the till is not always a shortage of people. Sometimes it is one approval that nobody can give

without a manager. Sometimes it is stock in the wrong place, so every sale starts with a walk to the back. Sometimes it is a till that needs someone to leave the counter to fetch a bag.

The bottleneck is the single step where the work slows down, no matter how much work arrives. Find it before you add anyone. Adding a person to a store with a bottleneck does not fix the queue. It just gives the queue more people to stand next to.

How to find it. Watch one busy block with a notebook. Note the moment a customer waits. Note what they are waiting for. Count the waits that come from each cause: till, stock, an approval, a system, a missing item. After one or two busy blocks you will usually see one cause that appears again and again. That is your bottleneck.

The psychology of why this matters is worth saying plainly. When we are busy and the queue is long, our attention narrows to the next customer. Under that pressure, the manager reaches for the most obvious fix, more staff, because it feels like effort and it is easy to ask for. The real cause is quieter and needs someone to stand back and look. That is the manager's job, and it is hard because standing back feels wrong when the store is full.

There is a second reason to find the bottleneck first: cost. Every extra hour of staff is a real cost, and every bottleneck removed is money that stays. When you ask for staff, you will have to explain what it will fix. If you have already removed the bottleneck and the store is still short, that is a strong, honest case.

Practice example: A fictional store's manager believes the till needs another person. She watches two busy blocks and counts forty-one customers who wait. Twenty-eight of them wait because a price change needs a supervisor's approval. She gives two trusted staff the authority to approve small price changes within a stated limit. The queue at the till in the peak block shrinks by about half, with no new staff. The counts and the limit are fictional and for practice only.

Reflect: Think of the last time your store was slow. What were customers waiting for, most often? You may not know yet. If you do not, that is your first job.

If you manage a store now: watch one busy block this week and note every wait and its cause. Do not change anything until you have the notes.

If you are not a store manager yet: in your section, watch the moment a customer waits and note what it is for. Interview question this answers: "The queue is too long on Saturdays. What would you do?"

The Disruption Plan

Things will break. A system goes down, a delivery is late, a person calls in sick, a promotion arrives with no stock. A disruption plan is a short, written answer to the question "what do we do when this happens?", written before it happens.

Keep it to one page and cover three things for each likely disruption: who takes charge, what the customer is told, and what is paused or dropped. The plan is not a list of everything that could go wrong. It is a short list of the disruptions that actually happen in your store.

Why bother? Under pressure, people freeze or improvise, and both cost time. A plan gives the team a shared first step, so they act instead of looking around for who is in charge. It also lets the manager step up to the bigger problem, because the smaller ones already have a home.

One more point. Put the plan where the team can find it, and talk through it once during a quiet block. A plan nobody has read is a document, not a plan.

Practice example: A fictional store's most common disruption is the till system going down. The plan names the supervisor on shift as the person in charge. The customer is told plainly that there is a technical problem and what the store will do. The plan pauses the stock count and the extra cleaning so everyone can help the queue. The store tests the plan on a quiet Tuesday with two staff.

Reflect: What is the most common disruption in your store? Write the first step, who takes charge, the customer line and what is paused.

If you manage a store now: write your one page plan for your two most likely disruptions.

If you are not a store manager yet: write the first three lines of a plan for your section. Interview question this answers: "Tell me about a time the store was under pressure. What did you do?"

Apply It in Your Role

Pick one step of the customer journey that has no clear owner. Name an owner today, and tell the team, out loud, why the step matters to the customer.

Look at your busiest block in the last week. Move one task out of it, or move one person's hours by a block. One change, not a plan.

Write one standard as an observable behavior, with the minimum version that holds on a busy day. Post it where you can see it, and check it twice this week.

Spend one busy block with a notebook and find the bottleneck. Do not add anyone until you have counted it.

Write the first three lines of a disruption plan. Use the one page format: who takes charge, what the customer hears, and what is paused.

If you manage a store now: do all five in your own store.

If you are not a store manager yet: do the same on your section or till area, or in the fictional store, and write the interview answer for each. The five short answers are a strong preparation set for a store manager interview.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each question before you look at the model answers. Never write real names or customer details.

1. Your district manager asks why Saturday afternoon was slow at the till. What exactly do you say?

2. A staff member says: "Nobody told me the collection shelf was my job." What do you say, and what do you change?

3. Your manager asks for two more staff members at weekends. You think the bottleneck is one approval. What do you say?

4. A new person asks you what "good service" means in this store. What do you say?

5. The till system goes down on a busy day. What are the first three things you do?

Key Takeaways

The customer journey is a sequence of steps, and every step needs one named owner.

Map your busiest block against your schedule. Put your strongest people at the peak, not in the quiet morning.

A standard is one observable behavior that holds on a bad day. Few standards, checked often, beat many standards never checked.

Find the bottleneck before adding staff. Watch one busy block with a notebook.

A disruption plan is one page, with who takes charge, what the customer hears, and what is paused.

Quiz

Answer the five questions below. One best answer each. The answers are in the Model Answers section.

1. What makes a good standard?

A. It is one observable behavior that holds on a busy day, checked often.
B. It is written in the team handbook and signed by everyone.
C. It covers every possible task so nothing is missed.
D. It is set by head office and never changed.

2. The till queue is long on Saturdays. What is the first step?

A. Add a staff member to the till for the whole day.
B. Watch one busy block and count what customers are waiting for.
C. Ask the team to work faster.
D. Remove the add-on questions at the till.

3. What does one named owner per journey step protect against?

A. Slow restocking.
B. Every step being left to the team to sort out, so no one is answerable for it.
C. High staff turnover.
D. Too many managers on shift.

4. Your busiest block is two until five in the afternoon, and the schedule has three staff on the floor in the morning. What is the best fix?

A. Add a person to the morning shift.
B. Ask the team to take turns on their breaks in the afternoon.

C. Move one shift later by two hours and put stock work in the quiet morning.

D. Keep the schedule and add an extra person to every shift.

5. What belongs in a disruption plan?

A. A list of every possible thing that could go wrong.

B. A full risk review for the district manager.

C. The names of every person to call if a system fails.

D. Who takes charge, what the customer is told, and what is paused.

Upskill Challenge

This is your practice for the next two days. Do one task, keep it small, and write down what you did.

If you manage a store now:

- ☐ Map the customer journey from walk-in to repeat visit in nine steps, with one owner under each.
- ☐ Match one busy block to your schedule and move one task or one block of hours.
- ☐ Write one standard as an observable behavior that holds on a bad day. Try it for one week.
- ☐ Watch one busy block with a notebook and write the bottleneck and its cause.
- ☐ Write a one page disruption plan for your two most likely disruptions.
- ☐ Prepare a short, honest update for your manager: what you tried, what happened, and one recommendation.

If you are not a store manager yet:

- ☐ Map the journey in your current section or till area, with one owner at each step you can see.
- ☐ Notice the effort and hurry in that block. Write what customers wait for, and who could own it.
- ☐ Write one standard for your section in observable terms, and check it once.
- ☐ Write the bottleneck you saw and how you would test it.
- ☐ Write your first three lines of a disruption plan, and practice saying them out loud.
- ☐ Write your answer to one common interview question on running a store: "How would you make sure a busy Saturday runs well?" Use the journey, the peak plan and the bottleneck in your answer.

Model Answers

These are examples. Your wording should sound like you. The principle matters more than the sentence.

1. "Saturday after two was slow at the till. I watched two busy blocks and most waits came from the price approval. I gave two staff the authority to approve small changes and it cleared. I recommend we keep that limit and review it next month." This reports facts first, then the fix, then a recommendation. It is what your manager needs, in one short answer.

2. "That was my miss. I did not name an owner for the collection shelf. You own the shelf when you are on that shift, and I will check it with you at the start of each hour." Name the gap as yours, name the owner, then agree the check. It is clear, calm and answerable.

3. "Before we add hours I want to count the waits. If most of them come from one approval, I can fix that for free with a limit on who can approve. If the queue is still long after that, I will bring you the case with the numbers." You keep the door open, and you bring evidence.

4. "Greeting every customer is what we want. But the behavior that must always hold is that we acknowledge every customer who reaches the till. That happens even on a busy day, and I check it." You give the standard and the reason it survives.

5. "First, the supervisor on shift takes charge. Second, the customer is told plainly there is a technical problem and what we will do. Third, I pause the stock count and the cleaning so everyone helps the queue." Who, what, and what is paused.

Quiz answers:

1. A. A standard you can see, that survives a busy day and is checked often, is the one that holds. The other options describe documents, not behavior.

2. B. You find the cause before you spend on staff. Watching one block and counting what customers wait for shows the real bottleneck.

3. B. A named owner makes the step answerable, so gaps become visible and fixable. A team cannot answer for a step.

4. C. Hours move to the peak, and tasks move to the quiet block, with no extra cost. Adding people does not fix a mismatch.

5. D. One page with three parts: who takes charge, the customer line, and what is paused. It is short, findable and practiced once.

References